One interpretation of the BJP's rise is that it was actually the 'outcome of the party riding on the support base of Rio's party, which in turn is roughly half of the original NPF's support base.' If there had not been a split in the NPF, and if the BJP had gone to the polls on its own, the journalist Pradip Phanjoubam felt that 'in all likelihood, its performance would not have been any better than in the 2013 assembly election'.[102] What is certain is that the BJP got the better end of the bargain in the alliance. 'We contested 40 seats but won 18. The BJP did much better, winning 12 out of 20 seats,' said Neiphiu Rio, the chief-ministerial face of the BJP–NDPP alliance. As Ram Madhav later explained, the alliance was very 'significant' because its 'adversaries like the NPF, who were fellow travelers until a few months ago, projected the BJP as a Hindutva party and unleashed the most communal campaign in the state. Yet, people supported the BJP.'[103]

Table 16.5: The BJP's Rise in Nagaland: 2018 Assembly Poll

Party	*Seats*	*Vote Share*
BJP	12	15.3%
NPF	27	38.8
JDU	1	4.5%
NDPP	18	25.2%
Independent	1	4.3%
Total	60	

Note: Elections were held in in fifty-nine seats; ECI data

The BJP's high strike rate in Nagaland illustrates the wider trend of its emergence as the predominant national party in the region. The Sangh saw the victory of the alliance as a vindication of the BJP's allegation that it had been vilified as a communal party. With the victories in Christian-dominated Nagaland and Meghalaya, *Organiser* declared that the 'tag of "Hindu Chauvinism" would now be countered forcefully'. Law and IT Minister Ravi Shankar Prasad delineated this further when he said, 'In spite of very vicious campaign against the BJP among the Christian minorities, the BJP